with fellow Asian countries was the rationale for hosting the first Asian Relations Conference in New Delhi on 23 March 1947, just months before India's independence. Under Nehru's leadership, India championed regional initiatives (such as the Afro-Asian Conference, also known as the Bandung Conference) as well as international organizations (most significantly the United Nations).[20] British India was one of the signatories to the United Nations (UN) Charter in 1945 and in 1947 independent India inherited the status of being one of the UN's founding members.

An analysis of Nehru's pronouncements on international affairs reflects the influence of colonial rule and the British legacy on his world view. For Nehru, India's neighbourhood included not just South Asia but West Asia (India's term for the Middle East), Central Asia and South-East Asia. Nehru chose different policies towards India's immediate periphery than towards distant countries or those in the broader Asian neighbourhood. Immediately after Independence and through the initial cold war years, for example, India sought to continue the British policy of buffer zones around India, especially to the north. It built close ties with Nepal and Bhutan in order to 'fortify its Himalayan defense structure'.[21]

India under Nehru also sought to prevent neighbours like Nepal, Bhutan and Sri Lanka from joining military alliances with either cold war bloc and was particularly irked by Pakistan's participation in Western military alliances. According to former foreign secretary J.N. Dixit, Nehru's 'sense of history' and awareness that India's neighbours were critical to India's security led him to adopt this policy. [22] Dixit argues that Nehru was aware of the asymmetry in size between India and its immediate neighbours. He sought to reassure these smaller neighbours by attempting to build ties on the basis of Panchasheel or principles of equality, non-interference and respect for territorial integrity.

Former diplomat and writer S.D. Muni asserts that Nehru had a Curzonian mindset – derived from the British imperialist Lord Curzon – on